

The Knight Rider

By Kaveree Bamzai

How do you know you're in the presence of a celebrity? When the security huddle around him is almost as recognisable as he is. And how do you know you're a celebrity sucker? When you can recognise them. That's what happened to me as I waited for Shah Rukh Khan in Kolkata.

Shah Rukh has that Clintonesque ability to grant you total focus, even if it is for 15-minute episodes at two-hour intervals. So as you piece together his profile, while following a Mercedes that trails a thin plume of that famous cigarette smoke, or sitting patiently behind very famous people, or speaking to him in between meetings, you know you have only a minor piece of a force of nature for a very transient period.

MULTI-TASKER
He's not just the brightest of Bollywood's best, SRK also juggles many jobs at the same time, and with equal élan

Shah Rukh virtually writes his own copy. He speaks fast, cutting and comic in turn. He's flown in from Paris, lost his luggage, lost his voice while cheering his IPL team, and signed a gazillion autographs, while checking on his children's school principal and rival team owner's wife, Nita Ambani's welfare, and preventing a friend's efforts to make him eat.

Khan calls himself an employee of Shah Rukh Khan Inc. And indeed, he seems more an envoy of his own multiple selves. Is he the writer of the all-caps slogans he shows on his laptop? Is he the father who misses his son? Is he the actor who can't stand to be beaten? My guess is this is a man who is constantly surprising himself, one minute a model businessman, another the world's most famous Muslim, and yet another its biggest star. And I suspect nothing else about this changeable star will remain the same.



Scrutable Orientals

By Sharda Ugra

They say language is a barrier in China. Barrier here does not mean an ineffectual police-picket of an obstacle. The Chinese language is a barrier of geological proportions, the Himalayas of mutual incomprehension. So one fine morning at the Beijing Olympics, China was sent into shock as its star athlete 110m hurdler Liu Xiang pulled out of the Games due to an injury. Every local face told a story which we could not tell because we didn't have the language to ask them.

Undaunted, a journalist-friend and I ventured outside the Olympic zone to speak to the 'man on the street'. We had to give up on the wisdom of alarmed mothers with babies, local loafers and two portly smokers who looked like Confucius and Lao Tse in vests and shorts because all were actually inscrutable. A sponsor's booth was made to supply a free interpreter and all passers-by were scrutinised. The first curious person who asked

GREAT SHOW
Fireworks are set off over the National Stadium during a rehearsal of the opening ceremony for the 2008 Beijing Olympic Games

REUTERS



about *us*—a young man from a neighbouring province—was enlisted. Who was responsible, we asked? Was he angry at Liu? Bitter? Our interpreter's stream of Mandarin spluttered. She whipped out a palm-sized gadget that looked like a cheap video-game and punched into it. It was a translator that turned our English into Mandarin characters which she showed the interviewee who looked at them, signed and began his nuanced reply.

He wasn't bitter or angry, he felt... and there we lost him in a debate over semantics with the interpreter. The gadget played bridge between civilisations again. He knew exactly what he was trying to say in Mandarin. The gadget told her there was actually words in it for English.

He felt regret, he said. Deep regret and pity. He then said, "It was some problem with Liu's body, not with his heart or his mind." That, there, was not merely the quote we had gone looking for, it was a passage of pure poetry. And even though it was in Chinese, we understood. ■